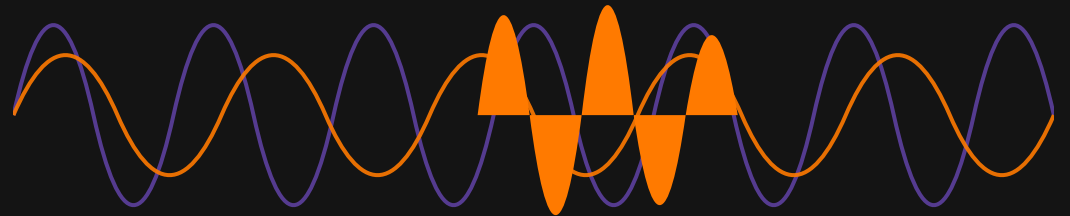


First *30* days ✨

How a beginner's first month in the JustinGuitar app could feel more like playing music, and less like homework.



Kira Krysanov

Product designer · October 2026

An independent, unsolicited concept, not affiliated with
Musopia or JustinGuitar.

I'd rather show you how I think than *tell you.*

Your mission is to help people's dream of playing an instrument come true. Most people who start don't make it through the first year, so the dream usually falls apart in the first few weeks. That's a design problem, and it's the one I'd most like to work on with you.

So instead of a cover letter, here is a small, end-to-end piece of work. I studied Musopia and its products, framed one problem, designed a concept for it, and planned how to test it. The concept is built around what JustinGuitar already does well: Justin's teaching, the Practice Assistant, One Minute Changes and the Instant Play Method.

I've only seen the product from the outside, so treat everything here as a set of hypotheses for us to question together.

Discovery

Interaction design

Hi-fi UI

Experiment design

Design system

MY FIRST 30 DAYS

Take the beginner course myself on the free guitar, read support tickets and store reviews, and sit in on data reviews.

60 DAYS

Run a first discovery and prototype cycle with product, data and engineering, and test with real learners.

90 DAYS

Ship a first experiment and contribute its components back to the design system with clear documentation.

INSIDE

01 What I learned

Musopia, its products, and what learners say about them

02 The problem worth solving

Where beginners give up, and why

03 Principles & flow

Five rules for the first month, and the journey they produce

04 The concept: six screens

Why-song onboarding, Today, listening One Minute Changes, progress, song unlocked, comeback

05 How we'd know it works

Hypotheses, metrics, guardrails and a rollout plan

06 System & handoff

Tokens, components and notes for a Unity build

A small Helsinki team with a *very big* classroom.

4.5M+

students reported for the JustinGuitar app, built with Justin Sandercoe

1,500+

songs and 210 lesson videos (36 h) across Grades 1–3

4.9★

App Store rating from 22k+ reviews (4.6 on Google Play)

~25

people in Vallila, Helsinki and remote, on three continents

The portfolio

JustinGuitar Lessons & Songs: a structured course with the Practice Assistant, 10-minute daily routines and a large play-along library. **Music Theory by Justin Guitar:** a newer companion app. **Kala:** a ukulele tuner, Color Chord lessons and a 2,000+ song songbook that listens to you play (500k+ downloads). The roots go back to **FourChords**, **Ukeoke** and ChordShaker, and to partnerships with Yamaha (GigMaker) and Little Kids Rock / Music Will in classrooms.

What makes it work

The **Instant Play Method** uses simplified chords, strum patterns, tempo control and lyrics, so you play a real song in minutes. Justin's teaching is calm, trusted and kind.

The pedagogy is real: **One Minute Changes** gives you one clear number to beat. Freemium subscriptions fund it all.

There's a brand that knows its voice too: *"ignite the music in you."*

Where learners feel friction

Progress doesn't sync between phone, tablet and the website

Lessons mention videos that only live on the website

Licensing removes songs, sometimes the one you were learning

The community asks "is it worth it?", so the value needs to be felt early

The neighbourhood

JustinGuitar shouldn't try to out-game the gamers. Its edge is a teacher people trust.

Yousician

Helsinki neighbour. Gamified, listens to your playing, multi-instrument.

Fender Play

Video course from a guitar maker, driven by retention in the hardware business.

Simply Guitar

Mic-based feedback and fast first songs. Strong at onboarding.

JustinGuitar

A human teacher with a proven method. The opportunity is to make that method feel alive on a phone.

Sources: musopia.net; JustinGuitar app listings on the App Store and Google Play; justinguitar.com and communityjustinguitar.com; Kala listing on Google Play and kalabrand.com; Tracxn and LinkedIn company data; FIBAN. Figures are as publicly reported in 2025–26.

02 · THE PROBLEM

Wanting to play is easy.
Staying is the hard part.

75%

of people would like to play
an instrument (Musopia)

90%

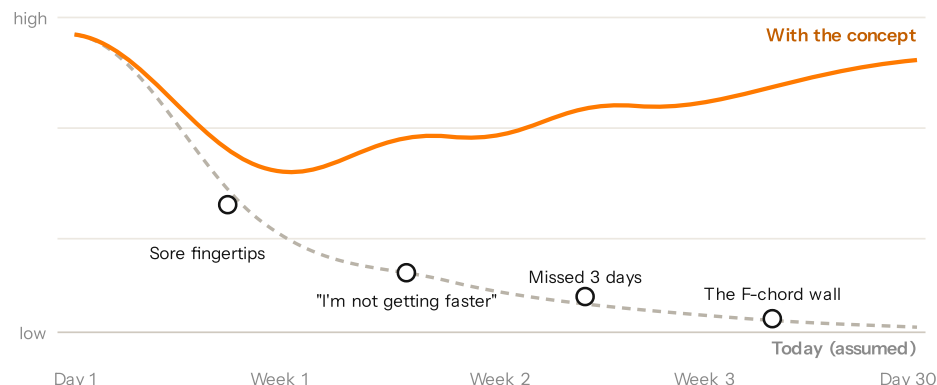
of new guitarists quit within 12
months (Fender, 2019)

Fender's CEO put it plainly: *"We don't have a problem attracting new entrants. We have a retention issue."* For a subscription app, the first weeks decide everything, including trial conversion, renewals, ratings and word of mouth.

Beginners quit for reasons that are physical and emotional before they are about content. Their fingers hurt, progress feels invisible, the songs they wanted feel far away, and one missed day turns into a missed week.

Motivation across a beginner's first month

Hypothesis to validate



How might we...

...make a beginner's **invisible progress**
visible, so the hard first weeks feel worth
it?

...and...

...keep the **song that made them start** in
sight from day one?

×2

"If we could reduce the abandonment rate by just 10 percent, we could double the size of the industry." (Andy Mooney, Fender). For Musopia, the same lever drives subscription lifetime value. That's why retention in the first month is the business case for this concept, and not just a UX nicety.

Sources: Fender / Andy Mooney via Guitar World & MusicRadar (2019); Musopia via FiBAN. The chart is an illustrative model for research, not measured data.

Five rules for the *first month*.

1

Song first

Every exercise is a step toward the song that made you start. The path is the curriculum, wrapped in the user's own reason.

2

Make progress visible

Calluses and muscle memory are invisible. Changes per minute are not. Measure the things that are improving and show them.

3

Rhythm, not streaks

Set a weekly target with rest days built in. Sore fingers need breaks, and a broken chain shouldn't make anyone feel like a failure.

4

No dead ends

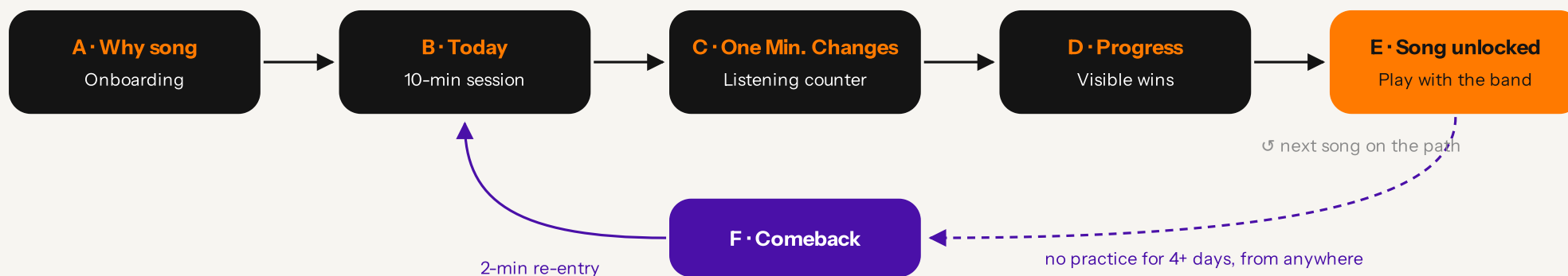
A hard chord should never stop the music. Instant Play always offers a simpler version, and the real one stays one tap away.

5

Sound like Justin

Every message is warm, specific and honest. "Your fingers remember more than you think" beats "Don't lose your streak!"

The journey, end to end



Questions I'd bring to the team

Kala already listens to playing. Can that detection be reused for chord changes on guitar?

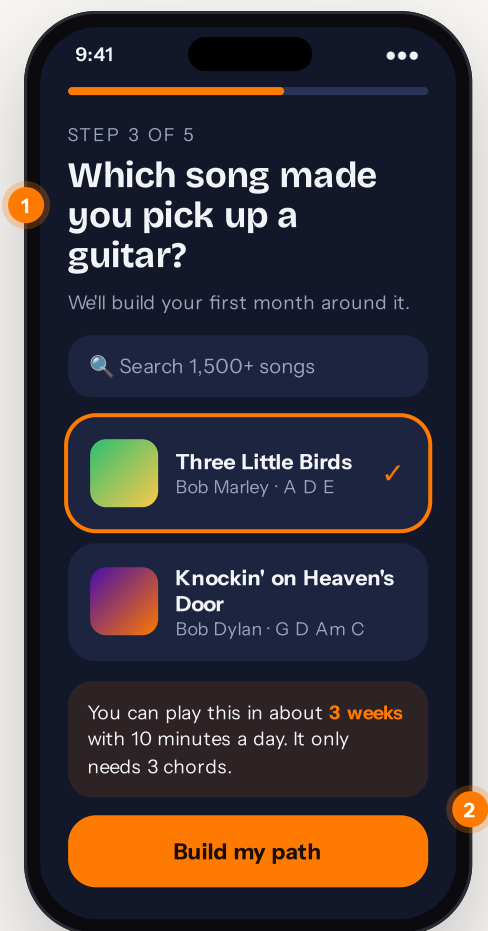
Where does the paywall sit compared with the first song unlock today, and what do the cohorts show?

Can why-songs come from a licence-stable list, so a goal never disappears?

How much of the first month happens on the website instead of the app, and how does that affect sync?

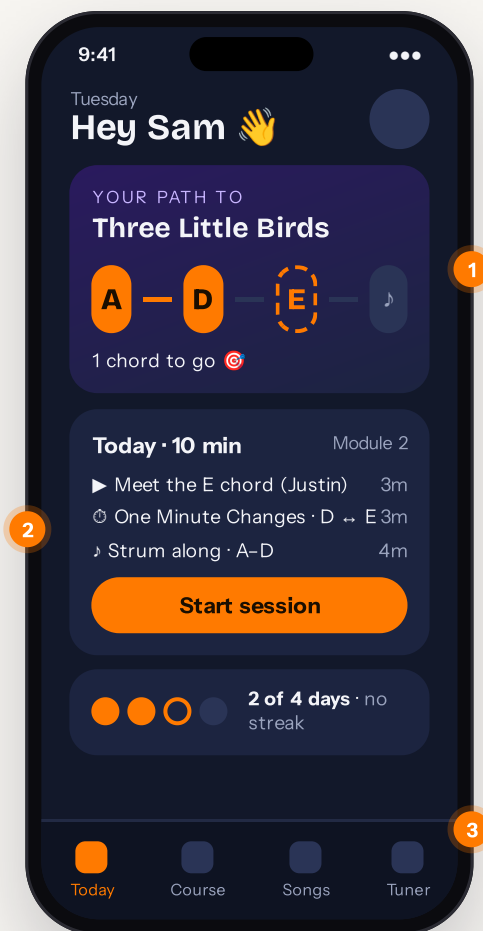
Start with the song. Practise *toward* it.

Shown in a dark JustinGuitar-style UI with Musopia orange as the action colour. Song titles are examples.



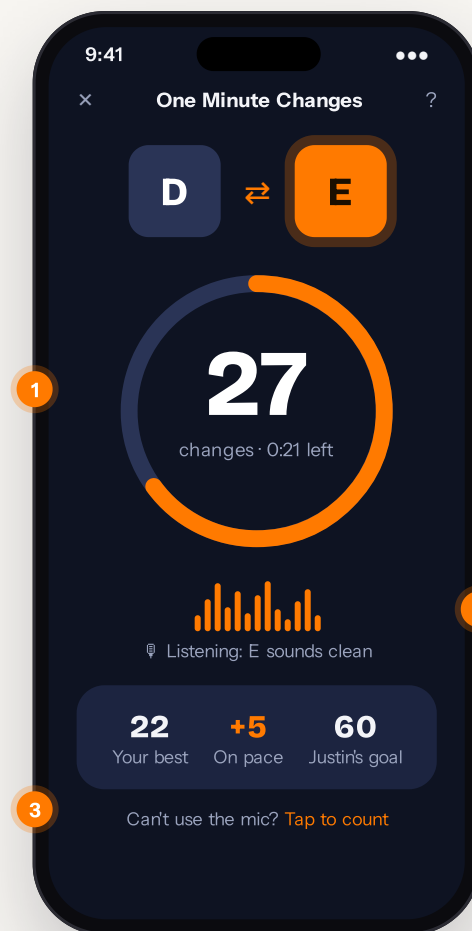
A • The why song

- The user's reason becomes the goal.** Choosing a song comes before choosing a level.
- An honest estimate** based on the chords the song needs. Easy songs come first, so the first win is close.



B • Today

- The song path:** the chords become checkpoints, and the song sits at the end.
- The Practice Assistant, made concrete:** one button and ten minutes.
- A weekly rhythm** the user chooses (4 days here). A missed day doesn't reset anything.

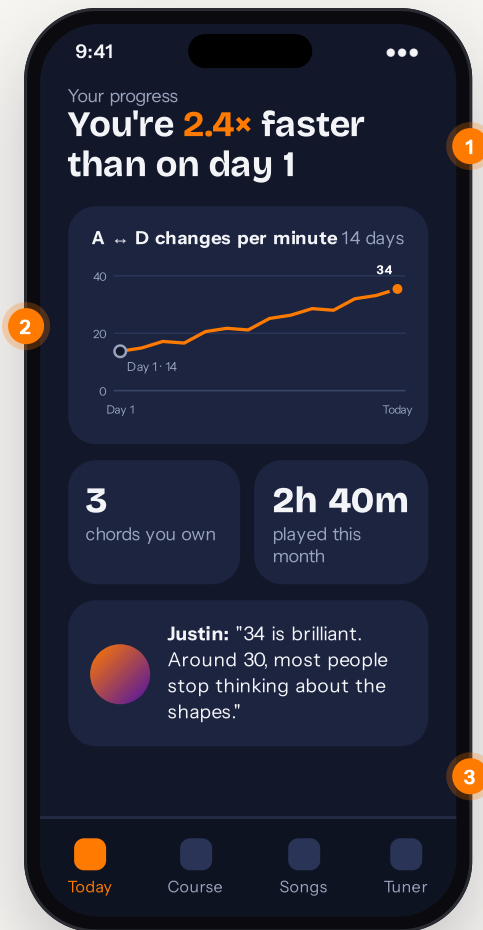


C • One Minute Changes that listen

- Justin's best exercise, now in the app:** the mic counts clean changes, so the user just plays.
- Compete with yourself, not a leaderboard.** The pace is shown against your personal best.
- Tap to count is always available** for noisy rooms, privacy or accessibility.

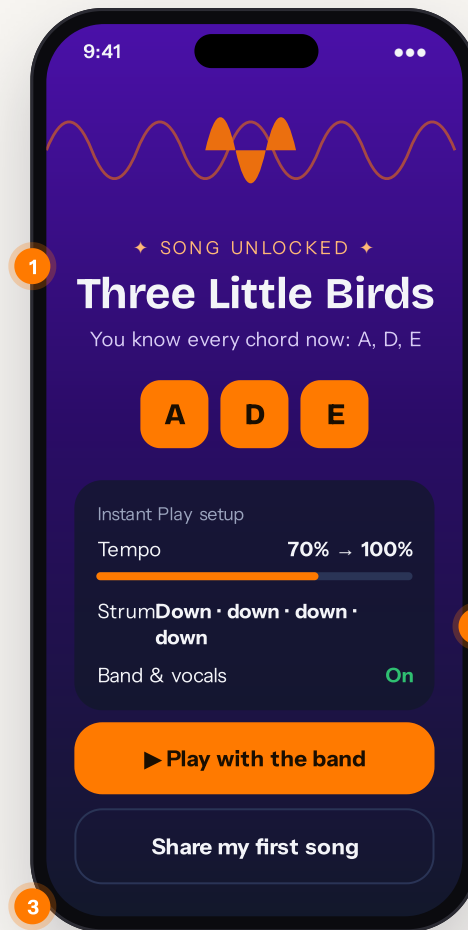
Show the wins. *Welcome* people back.

Values in the screens are example data from one learner's month.



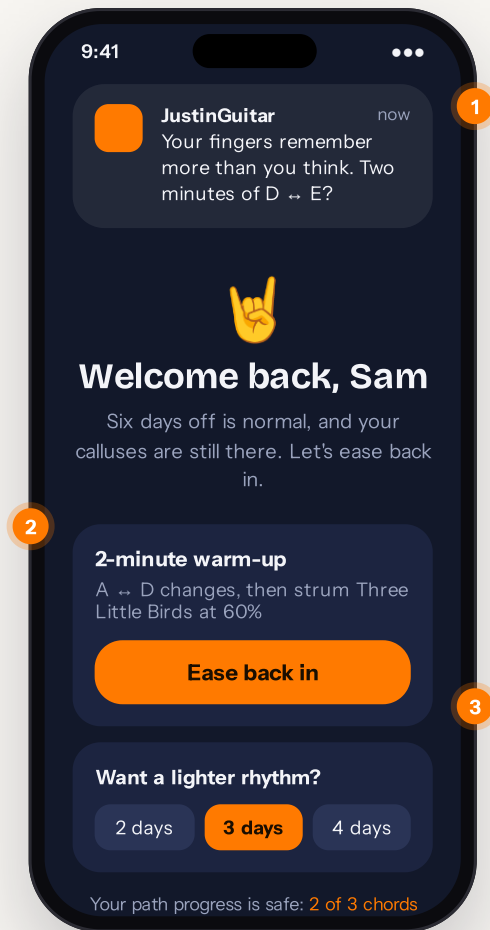
D • Visible progress

- One headline in plain language** that compares the user only with themselves.
- A real skill curve** built from the One Minute Changes data the app already collects.
- Justin's voice at milestones**, using short pre-recorded lines to keep the human connection.



E • The payoff moment

- A celebration that uses the brand:** Musopia's waveform and the sparkle, used sparingly.
- Instant Play starts slow** and speeds up, so the first play-through is a success.
- Sharing is optional** and only offered at a proud moment. It's a quiet growth loop.



F • The comeback

- Specific, kind nudges** that suggest the next tiny action. No guilt about streaks.
- Re-entry is shorter than a normal session.** Two minutes lowers the barrier more than ten.
- The plan adapts:** lowering the weekly goal counts as a success, not a failure.

Ship it as experiments, *not as a bet.*

#	WE BELIEVE...	WE'LL KNOW IF...
H1	Choosing a why song during onboarding makes the first month feel personal	D7 retention and the share of users who finish their first session go up for new installs
H2	Listening One Minute Changes plus a progress curve make improvement feel real	More practice days in weeks 2–4, and more users reach 30 changes per minute
H3	A weekly rhythm with kind comebacks keeps more people than daily streaks	More lapsed users come back within 14 days, and fewer turn off notifications
H4	Feeling an early song unlocked moment makes paying feel worth it	Trial-to-paid conversion and month-2 renewals go up

North star

Learners who play their first full song within 30 days. This lines up value for users with revenue.

Guardrails

Onboarding completion, mic-permission drop-off, refund rate, store rating, crash-free sessions.

Rollout

Weeks 1–2 · Discover

Interview 8–10 lapsed and active beginners, review cohort data around days 3–10, and set the D7 and D30 baselines.

Weeks 3–4 · Prototype & test

Run a clickable Figma prototype with 5–6 beginners holding a real guitar. Test the mic accuracy of chord-change detection with engineering.

Weeks 5–8 · Ship H1 + H3

Start with the cheapest changes, the onboarding question and the weekly rhythm, as an A/B test on new installs in one market.

Weeks 9+ · Ship H2 + H4

Add listening One Minute Changes and the unlock moment, then iterate on the cohort curves.

EVENTS TO INSTRUMENT

```
why_song_selected · session_started{source} · omc_completed{pair,
count, input} · path_chord_mastered · song_unlocked ·
rhythm_goal_changed · comeback_shown/accepted
```

Usability test script (weeks 3–4), with a guitar in hand

Task 1

"Set the app up to learn a song you love."

Pass: finds or swaps a why song in under 60 s, and understands the time estimate.

Task 2

"Do today's practice."

Pass: starts without help and can say why each step is there.

Task 3

"Do a one-minute chord change."

Pass: trusts the count. We log the gap between mic and observed counts and how often people fall back to tapping.

Task 4

"You skipped a week. Open the app."

Pass: describes the feeling as "welcome", not "guilty", and finishes the 2-minute re-entry.

Built to slot into a *design system*, and into Unity.

Tokens

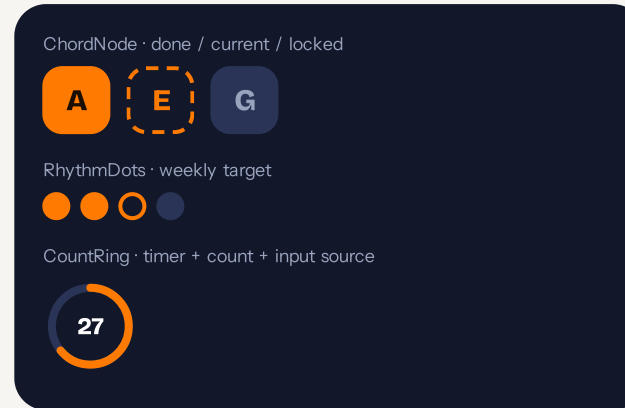


Display: Bricolage

Body: Instrument Sans

These are stand-ins for Musopia's own typefaces. Use a 4-pt spacing scale and radii of 10, 14 and 29.

New components



Each component has defined states, including empty, loading, offline and mic-denied, before it's handed off.

Notes for a Unity build

- Export tokens as JSON from Figma variables so Unity UI and native screens read **one source of truth**.
- Spec motion in **ms with easing curves** (unlock: 600 ms, ease-out-back). The waveform is one looping asset.
- Agree on the chord-detection confidence threshold with engineering. Under the threshold, **don't count, don't scold**.
- Give every surface a **sync status**, which responds to the most common store complaint.
- Run accessibility checks: AA contrast on dark surfaces, Dynamic Type up to 200%, and a tap-to-count alternative to the mic.

CountRing states: designed before handoff



THANKS FOR READING

Let's help more people *stay* with the music.

I'd love to walk you through this concept, hear where it's wrong, and learn what you already know from your data. I'll take the free ukulele too.

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This independent concept was made for the Musopia Senior Product Designer application. JustinGuitar, Kala and Musopia are the property of their owners. Product facts are from public sources, and all screen data is illustrative.